of the colour is directly proportional to the amount of the antigen. ELISA is highly sensitive and can detect antigens in the range of a nanogram.

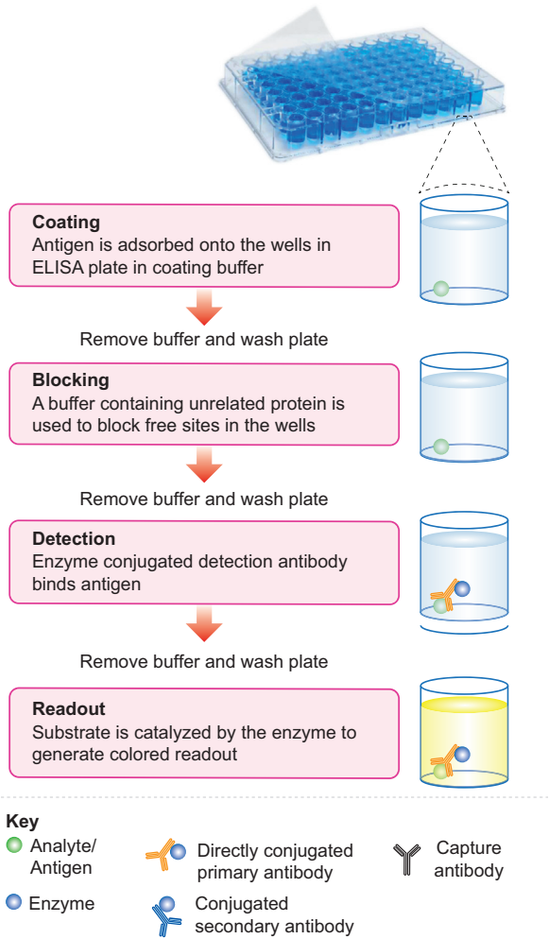


Fig. 9.5 Enzyme Linked Immuno Sorbent Assay

There are four kinds of ELISA namely, Direct ELISA, Indirect ELISA, sandwich ELISA and competitive ELISA. It is a highly sensitive and specific method used for diagnosis. ELISA possesses the added advantages of not requiring radioisotopes or a radiation counting apparatus.

PCR (Polymerase Chain Reaction)

The polymerase chain reaction (PCR) is an *invitro* amplification technique used for synthesising multiple identical copies (billions) of DNA of interest. The technique was developed by **Kary Mullis** (Nobel laureate, 1993) in the year 1983.

Denaturation, renaturation or primer annealing and synthesis or primer extension, are the three steps involved in PCR **(Fig. 9.6)**. The double stranded DNA of interest is denatured to separate into two individual strands by high temperature . This is called **denaturation**. Each strand is allowed to hybridize with a primer (renaturation or primer annealing). The primer template is used to synthesize DNA by using Taq – DNA polymerase (isolated from the bacterium Thermus aquaticus).

During denaturation the reaction mixture is heated to 95^0 C for a short time to denature the target DNA into single strands that will act as a template for DNA synthesis. Annealing is done by rapid cooling of the mixture, allowing the primers to bind to the sequences on each of the two strands flanking the target DNA. During primer extension or synthesis the temperature of the mixture is increased to 75^0C for a sufficient period of time to allow Taq DNA polymerase to extend each primer by copying the single stranded template. At the end of incubation both single template strands will be made partially double stranded. The new strand of each double stranded DNA extends to a variable distance downstream. These steps are repeated again and again to generate multiple forms of the desired DNA. This process is also called DNA amplification.

The PCR technique can also be used for amplifications of RNA in which case it is referred to as reverse transcription PCR (RT-PCR). In this process the RNA molecules (mRNA) must be converted to complementary DNA by the enzyme reverse transcriptase. The cDNA then serves as the template for PCR.

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